

The one-page design memo

Your own question this time. One page, built in an hour, and then handed to someone who will break it.

What you will hold at the end: one sheet of A4 you could put in front of your director tomorrow morning — and two things written on it that you did not know when the hour began.

Start from your own question

5 min

Not the practice dataset. **The national problem you wrote on the ninja form this morning.** You already built three rival hypotheses for it in the first exercise — open that page and continue from there.

One rule for the whole hour: the AI is a tool, not the writer. Every sentence that ends up on your sheet is a sentence you decided to keep.

Build the memo

20 min

```
#role a research designer preparing a one-page project memo
#task turn my issue and hypotheses into a one-page design memo
#context [paste your issue, your three rival hypotheses, and the
  refuting observation you wrote for each]
#constraints six short sections - the question, why it matters now,
  the three rival explanations, what data would separate them, what
  I already have and what I would need, one honest limitation
#format one page, headed sections, no citations in the body
```

Stop and look. Read what came back and ask one question of it: **which of these sentences did I already know before today?** Everything else is a claim you have not checked yet. Mark those. They are not wrong — they are unverified, and the difference matters when someone asks you about them in a meeting.

Then let it attack the memo, once

```
#role a sceptical reviewer from the Ministry of Finance
#task give me your three strongest objections to this memo
#constraints one of them must be about cost or feasibility
#format numbered, one sentence each
```

That constraint is doing real work. Without it you get academic objections, which are interesting. With it you get the objection that actually stops a project — and the person who will raise it is not a reviewer, they are the one holding the budget.

✓ Keep one objection on your sheet. A memo with no visible weakness reads as a memo written by someone who has not looked.

Keep it to one page

Ask for a page and you will often be handed three. Cut it back yourself. **A design that will not fit on one page is usually a design you do not yet understand** — the cutting is not formatting work, it is the thinking.



What your data will never see — and who can break your memo

The audit, the sparring, and how to leave the hour with something that survives until tomorrow.

The audit: what your design cannot capture

15 min

You did this to a fictional study an hour ago. Now do it to your own.

```
#role a qualitative researcher
#task list the explanations for my research question that my
  planned data could NOT capture
#context my planned variables are [list them]
#constraints for each, name who I would have to talk to in order to
  find it, and the one question I would have to ask them
#format explanation | who to talk to | the question to add
```

Then write these two lines **by hand**, on the sheet:

What my design could never see: _____

Who I must talk to in order to find it: _____

Do not let the AI write these two lines. It does not know your country, your ministry, or which door you can actually knock on. It can list the blind spots; only you know whose name goes in the second line. **A column that does not exist cannot be controlled for** — and no statistic added later will rescue a question you never asked.

Sparring: swap sheets

15 min

Exchange your memo with the person next to you. Seven minutes each way. The reader has exactly two jobs:

1. **Name one observation that would kill their favourite hypothesis.**
2. **Name one thing they are not measuring** — one missing column.

Praise is banned for fifteen minutes. "This looks good" carries no information. If you cannot find a weakness, you have not read closely enough — read it again and find one.

This is the only part of the hour that no machine can do for you. The person beside you knows your country, knows your institution, and knows where next year's budget comes from. **No model knows any of that.**

Doing this alone, later

The drill still works with one person, but it needs a gap. Finish the memo, put it away, and read it the next morning in the finance reviewer's voice, out loud. Better still: find one real colleague. An AI that plays the sceptic is useful practice; it is not the same as someone who will have to live with the result.

Get it out of the conversation

5 min

Before you close anything, put today into one file — a plain text file, a Word document, a note. Four headings, nothing more:

```
## What I decided          (one dated line each)
## Still open              (leave them as questions)
## Sources I used          (links and page numbers)
## The paragraph I paste into AI next time
```

✓ The AI does not remember this conversation. Tomorrow it starts from nothing. **Your file is the only memory in the room that lasts.**

